Afterword: China in the Post-Ukraine War World

One of the hazards most authors face is of their books being out of date by the time they have seen the light of day. Since my handing over the completed manuscript of this book to my publishers, the world around us has been thrown into an unprecedented and dangerous tumult by Russia's ill-conceived invasion of Ukraine. The many grievances that Russia has had against the present political dispensation in Kyiv and the series of provocative moves by NATO to extend the alliance right up to the borders of Russia cannot justify the invasion, much less the barbaric violence and destruction unleashed on the innocent men, women and children of Ukraine.

It is not clear how this war will end, but no outcome will qualify as a victory for Putin's Russia. Russia was already a declining economy and a much diminished power since the end of the Cold War. Its decline as a major power is likely to accelerate as a result of this war. The comprehensive and sweeping sanctions imposed on Russia by the US and the Western countries in general have literally unplugged Russia from the global economic and financial system. In geopolitical terms, Russia has, by its aggressive actions, triggered a degree of unity and cohesion in Europe that is unprecedented.

For the first time since the end of the Cold War, European countries will be spending much more on their own defence. The US has led the Western response through its own severe bilateral sanctions on Russia and also through a global diplomatic offensive to isolate Russia internationally. This has created a dilemma for countries friendly to Russia, including India and China, but much more so for China, which, just weeks before the invasion, had signed up a Sino-Russian strategic partnership with 'no limits' and had declared that there were 'no forbidden areas' for cooperation between the